AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

PLAYER INSTRUCTIONS

Start here. Print only what you need, protect the sealed page, and investigate together.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

SETUP / 1-6 INVESTIGATORS

What is in the box?

PDF	Contents
01 Story	28 pages: cover, briefing, 24 narrative chapters, cast and next steps.
02 Character Cards	Six large portrait dossiers and four reference cards.
03 Clues & Evidence	Twelve numbered exhibits. E09 is sealed until the code is solved.
04 Puzzle Sheets	P1-P3 code tasks and P4-P6 deduction worksheets.
05 Solution Guide	Graduated hints, answers, accusation, reconstruction and scoring.
06 Player Instructions	Contents, setup, rules and a folded code check.

You also need pencils and blank paper. Scissors and envelopes are optional. No app, account, internet search or real combination lock is needed. Recommended age 14+; fictional death, financial deception and mild tension, with no graphic imagery.

The pack uses English throughout. Estimated playtime is 90-120 minutes including reading, depending on group pace. This is a cooperative case, not a live role-playing murder party.

ASSEMBLY & SPOILER CONTROL

Prepare the evidence

1. Read the story. Everyone may read or share the reading aloud. The 24 short chapters stop before the accusation.

2. Share the dossiers. All six suspect cards are public. Nobody secretly acts as a suspect or receives a murderer role.

3. Set aside E09. In the evidence PDF, locate the page headed E09. Print every other exhibit first. Print E09 separately and place it in an envelope marked E09. The cover is page 1.

4. Keep the other exhibits open. E01-E08 and E10-E12 may be read in any order after the story. E08 is a later comparison report; its timestamp is after the narrative, which is intentional.

5. Solve P1-P3. Check the code using a facilitator or the folded strip on this booklet's final page. A correct check permits E09.

6. Submit before revealing. Read E09, complete P4-P6, and make one written accusation. Only then open the full solution.

SCREEN PLAY

E09 is clearly labeled SEALED. Avoid thumbnails and continuous scrolling past it. Open the other pages directly. If nobody can supervise, cover that page onscreen until you have checked the code.

RULES, TIMING & PRINTING

Investigate fairly

Timing suggestion: 25-35 minutes story; 20-25 minutes exhibits and cards; 15-20 minutes puzzles; 15-25 minutes discussion and accusation; 5-10 minutes reveal. Take breaks when needed.

Evidence rules: Written exhibit observations are authoritative. Cover art, portraits and the library illustration set the mood; they are not forensic photographs. The labeled textile schematic explains a recorded observation. Colour alone is never required to solve a task.

Do not add facts: No hidden accomplice, secret tunnel, altered clock, supernatural event or specialist test is needed. Differentiate a witness's claim from a verified event.

Hints: A facilitator may read one hint from the Solution Guide hint section without revealing subsequent pages. In solo play, cover the lower hints and reveal only one at a time.

Printing: A4, actual size or fit to printable area. Print evidence and worksheets single-sided. Story may be duplex. Colour is recommended for artwork but the text, labelled values and stitch descriptions work in grayscale.

Reusable play: Keep a clean master. Write on photocopies of P4-P6. Optional reference cards may be cut from their boxes; the six portrait dossiers work as full-page cards.

WIN CONDITION

The team succeeds by naming the culprit, explaining the motive and method, and supporting the case with evidence rather than a guess. Puzzles alone do not solve the crime.

OPTIONAL / FOLD BEFORE PLAY

A check without the reveal

This page contains the dispatch-box combination only. It contains no culprit name. Ask someone who is not playing to fold the lower panel backwards before handing you the booklet, or keep it covered until you have solved P1-P3.

If your answer matches, open E09. If it does not, recheck the rule on P2 and the corrected appointment on P3. A facilitator can simply tell you "matches" or "does not match".

FOLD LOWER PANEL BACK / COVER UNTIL READY

4 1 7

Correct match: open evidence E09.

No scoring penalty for checking once you have an answer.